

Aptenodytes forsteri

Emperor penguin



Location Circumpolar around Antarctica

Height 3½ ft (1.1 m)
Weight Up to 82 lb (37 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened



The largest of all the penguins, this bird has highly unusual breeding habits. In winter, the female lays one egg and goes to sea, not returning until the spring. The male carries the egg on his feet and protects it with a “pouch” of feathery skin, huddling with other incubating males to keep warm. He fasts until his mate returns, just as the chick hatches, and then goes to sea, later returning to help rear the chick. This species can dive to depths of 1,750 ft (530 m) for as long as 20 minutes, and travel up to 625 miles (1,000 km) on foraging trips.

Pygoscelis adeliae

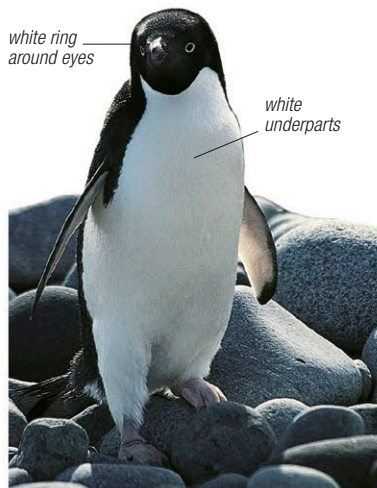
Adelie penguin



Location Circumpolar around Antarctica

Height 18–24 in (46–61 cm)
Weight 8¼–12 lb (4–5.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

One of the few penguins that nests on mainland Antarctica, along shores that are free of ice in summer, the Adelie penguin is mainly blue-black with pure white underparts and a distinctive white ring around its eye. It breeds in summer in vast colonies of 200,000 or more synchronized pairs, each female laying 2 eggs roughly 2 days apart. Both the male and the female incubate the eggs in shifts. The Adelie penguin is relatively aggressive, and adults are often observed stealing rocks from their neighbors’ nests.



Pygoscelis antarcticus

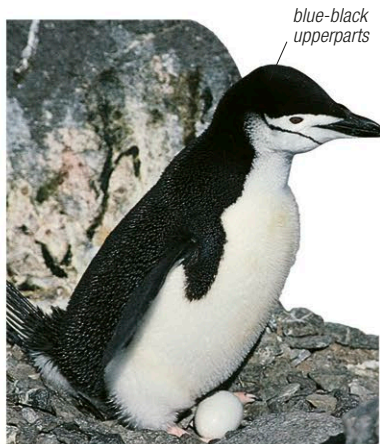
Chinstrap penguin



Location Circumpolar around Antarctica

Height 28–30 in (71–76 cm)
Weight 6½–10 lb (3–4.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Characterized by a thin, black line that runs from ear to ear under the chin, the chinstrap penguin is mostly blue-black with white underparts, cheeks, chin, and throat. It prefers areas of light pack ice, and breeds in high-density, sometimes large, colonies on ice-free areas of coasts. The nests comprise a circular platform of small stones, with a shallow nest cup, and often include bones and feathers. The breeding success of chinstrap penguins is highly variable: it is lower in years when sea ice persists close to colonies, since this restricts access to the sea for foraging adults.



Spheniscus humboldti

Humboldt penguin

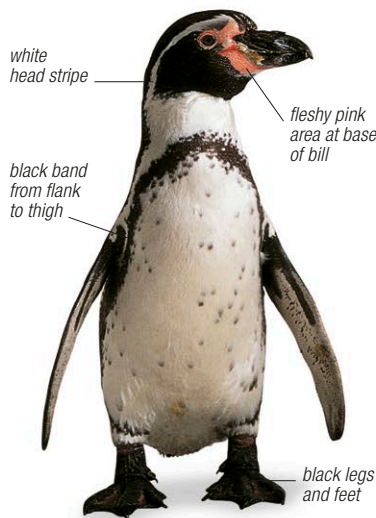


Location W. South America

Height 22–26 in (56–66 cm)
Weight 10–11 lb (4.5–5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable

Small colonies of this penguin occur along the west coast of South America, in the cold but fish-rich Humboldt Current. Coloration is mostly blackish gray with white underparts, but adults have a distinctive black, horseshoe-shaped breast band and a white head stripe. The penguins usually hunt in groups in shallow water, pursuing small, schooling fish such as anchovies

and sardines, and they nest in underground burrows, caves, or crevices between boulders. Direct hunting and over-fishing by humans have led to a decline in their population.



Eudyptula minor

Little penguin

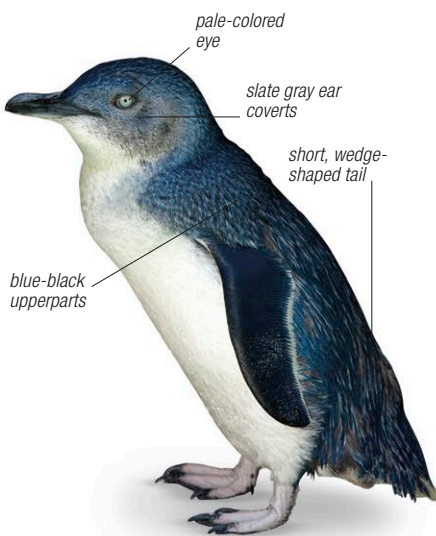


Location S. Australia (including Tasmania), New Zealand

Height 16 in (41 cm)
Weight 2¼ lb (1 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

This mainly blue-gray bird is the smallest species of penguin, and also one of the few that remain fully active after dark. During the day it forages at sea, but after sunset in the breeding season, it returns to land, coming ashore under the cover of darkness. A highly vocal bird, it calls at sea and on land. Little penguins normally nest in underground burrows, but they also breed in caves, crevices, under vegetation among rocks, and sometimes under houses. They lay

2 eggs on a bed of sticks or grass, and the parents take turns at incubation. Chicks are brooded for 7–10 days and guarded for a further 13–20 days. At sea, the little penguin feeds alone or in small groups, catching small fish and swallowing them beneath the surface.



Eudyptes chrysolophus

Macaroni penguin



Location S. Chile, South Atlantic, S. Indian Ocean

Height 28 in (71 cm)
Weight 7¾–14 lb (3.5–6.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable

Like all 7 species of crested penguins, the macaroni penguin has a conspicuous crest of golden plumes on its head. It also has a large, bulbous, orange-brown bill, often ridged in adults. Noisy, aggressive, and demonstrative, it makes raucous braying sounds in its colonies on land and gives short barks at sea. Although 2 eggs are laid, only

one chick ever survives to the fledgling stage—usually the chick from the second, larger egg. Both sexes share incubation duties but, unlike most other penguins, the female takes the first shift.

